Sebastian Melo-Martin

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Citizenship: Colombia | Canadian Permanent Resident

Education

2021 – 2027 (Expected)	**University of British Columbia** Ph.D. in Economics
2015 – 2017	**Universidad de los Andes, Colombia** M.A. in Economics
2011 – 2015	**Universidad de los Andes, Colombia** B.A. in Economics

Research Fields

Labor Economics

Applied Microeconomics

Public Economics

References

Professor David Green
David.Green@ubc.ca

Professor Raffaele Saggio
rsaggio@mail.ubc.ca

Professor Thomas Lemieux
Thomas.Lemieux@ubc.ca

Professor Sam Norris
sam.norris@ubc.ca

Placement Director

Professor Raffaele Saggio
rsaggio@mail.ubc.ca

Research

Job Market Paper

Who Bears the Shock? Unions, Early Retirement, and Firm Adjustment

How do unions shape the way firms and workers adjust to negative shocks? I study the decline in export demand during the 2008 financial crisis using Canadian matched employer-employee tax records that identify collective agreement coverage for every worker. Union and non-union firms experiencing similar shocks reduce employment by comparable amounts, but through different mechanisms. Non-union firms cut hiring and reduce the pay of the workers who stay. In contrast, union firms protect incumbent earnings, including those of workers not covered by the agreement, and adjust primarily through separations. The workers who bear these job losses are not the ones seniority-based theories would predict. Separations at union firms are concentrated among older, long-tenured workers, many of whom retire with employer pensions. This pattern does not appear at non-union firms and provides novel evidence that union status determines whether firms use early retirement to respond to negative shocks. I also show that the combined value of pensions and additional leisure for each induced retiree is similar to their pre-shock earnings. These findings suggest that unions serve as a form of insurance, protecting wages and turning job losses among older workers into early retirements.

Research (continued)

Work in Progress

Do Active Labor Market Programs Help Disadvantaged Populations? Evidence from Linked Income Assistance Records (with Kelly Foley, Vince Hopkins, Ada Litvinov, and Shan Wei)

The Indirect Effects of the Green Energy Transition on Income Distribution: Evidence from the Lithium Supply Chain in Chile (with Daniel Guzman)

Financial Inclusion of the Poor and Money Laundering Indicators: Empirical Evidence for Colombia (with Hernando Bayona and Catherine Rodriguez)

Book Chapters

Inclusión financiera y lavado de activos: evidencia empírica para Colombia (with Hernando Bayona and Catherine Rodriguez). In ECONOMÍA Y SEGURIDAD EN EL POSCONFLICTO. Bogotá,Colombia: Universidad de los Andes,Ediciones Uniandes

Research Experience

2024 – 2026 **University of British Columbia.** Research Assistant.

2018 – 2021 **The World Bank.** Research Analyst.

2015 – 2017 **Universidad de los Andes.** Research Assistant.

Teaching Experience

Fall 2023 – Fall 2025 **Topics in Applied Econometrics (Graduate)**
Teaching Assistant, University of British Columbia

Fall 2024 – Fall 2025 **Labor Economics (Graduate)**
Teaching Assistant, University of British Columbia

Summer 2025 **Applied Economics (Graduate)**
Teaching Assistant, University of British Columbia

2022 – Fall 2023 **International Trade (Undergraduate)**
Teaching Assistant, University of British Columbia

2015 — 2017 **Long-run Macroeconomics (Undergraduate)**
Teaching Assistant, Universidad de los Andes

Introduction to Macroeconomics (Undergraduate)
Teaching Assistant, Universidad de los Andes

Awards and Fellowships

2025 – Present Stone Centre on Wealth and Economic Inequality Fellowship, University of British Columbia

2023 Small Grants in Innovative Data, Centre for Innovative Data in Economics Research (CIDER), University of British Columbia

2021 – Present President's Academic Excellence Initiative PhD Award, University of British Columbia

Faculty of Arts Graduate Award, University of British Columbia

International Tuition Award, University of British Columbia

Skills

Software Skills	Stata, R, GIS software (ArcGIS, QGIS), Julia, Python
Languages	Spanish (native); English (fluent)